



THE EDELVAULT SERIES 2026

WHITE PAPER

The Swiss Financial Hub: From Vault to Vault





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Edelvault SA



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Introduction

This white paper draws on The Edelvault Series, “The Swiss Financial Hub: From Vault to Vault,” a five-day program of interviews and panel discussions held at the TEK Terrace during the 2026 Montreux Jazz Festival. The series brought together 26 speakers from banking, wealth and asset management, financial infrastructure, digital assets, law, regulation, and academia in around 25 interviews, conversations, and panels.



The program moved from past to future, from context to implementation. Day 1 examined how Switzerland developed as an international financial center and the capabilities that it acquired thanks to its history. Day 2 shifted the focus to the forces changing client demand. Day 3 assessed how the Swiss model is responding to innovation, digital assets, AI, and sustainability. Day 4 moved from strategy to implementation, examining how digital assets and AI are changing portfolio management and the broader wealth-management value chain. Day 5 brought these perspectives together to consider how wealth management could evolve by 2035 and what role Switzerland could play in shaping this evolution.

Switzerland has built one of the world's leading wealth-management centers by combining capabilities developed over generations: international expertise, discretion, long-term thinking, world-class service and infrastructure, and institutional stability. While these capabilities continue to underpin its position, the environment in which they are applied is changing. Wealth increasingly spans jurisdictions, generations, legal structures, providers, and asset classes, with technology changing how assets are accessed, analyzed, held, and managed. At the same time, international competition is raising the bar for financial centers.

The central question of this paper follows from these changes: How should the Swiss wealth-management model evolve as client needs, financial markets, and technology change, while building on the capabilities that have historically undergirded its competitiveness?

This question provides the thread connecting the five days of discussions captured in the following chapters. This white paper has two objectives: first, to synthesize the main insights from the interviews and panels, identifying the key takeaways; second, to translate these insights into practical guidance for wealth management, drawing on both the discussions themselves and the relevant secondary literature.



I would once again like to thank HUB+ and Lilian Nordet, with whom I conceived and brought the Edelvault Series to life in Montreux and will continue to develop it beyond this event, Everything, for its contribution to making the Series possible, and our valued partners, the Crypto Valley Association, Allnews, Women in Web3, the Montreux Jazz Festival Foundation, and the TEK team. I would also thank all the speakers and participants who contributed to the discussions in Montreux.

I wish you an enjoyable read.

Marc Lebel

Founder and CEO Edelvault SA



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The Roots of the Swiss Wealth-Management Model

Day 1 was dedicated to the question of how Switzerland acquired the capabilities that have come to be associated with international wealth management. The country exhibits expertise, savoir faire, and values that derive from different periods: knowledge of international markets, discretion, long investment horizons, legal and institutional stability, specialist infrastructure, a service culture, and the ability to adapt to changing external conditions. This chapter correspondingly treats the Swiss model as an accumulated practice rather than an inherited identity. The central question addressed here is not whether these capabilities existed in the past, but how they came to reinforce one another and under what conditions they remain useful. This distinction is important for what follows, since Switzerland built up its position through the structures and decisions that shaped it as a financial center and its future status will depend both on how these structures evolve and on how actors in the financial sector respond to changing conditions. Its accumulated expertise, institutions, and credibility provide the resources necessary for this adaptation.



2.1 How It All Started: Three Centuries of Building the Swiss Financial Hub

Although banks had been operating in Switzerland for centuries, the historian Dr Marc Perrenoud dated the country's emergence as a financial center to the late nineteenth century. At this time, cantonal banks and savings institutions expanded, followed by large banks such as Credit Suisse and the Société de Banque Suisse, as well as major insurance companies. The Swiss National Bank was established in 1907, followed by the Swiss Bankers Association in 1912. By 1914, Switzerland had the institutions necessary to create a national financial center.

Perrenoud identified the First World War as a turning point, as the Swiss franc acquired international importance, large Swiss banks became less dependent on leading foreign banks, and Switzerland emerged in a stronger position than several other European financial centers damaged by the conflict. He linked subsequent foreign-capital inflows to low taxation, along with political and monetary stability. The establishment of the Bank for International Settlements in Basel in 1930 confirmed Switzerland's growing international role.

The Second World War further strengthened Switzerland's role in this domain, while also exposing it to political pressure. In 1939, Credit Suisse and the Société de Banque Suisse opened branches in New York. From 1940 on, both the Allied and the Axis powers sought to obtain Swiss francs, while Switzerland handled a large share of Germany's international financial transactions. Perrenoud described a double movement of "globalization and Helvetization": Swiss banks expanded abroad, while increasing their independence from larger foreign financial powers. The political and diplomatic effects of neutrality were important, allowing Switzerland to maintain economic relations across a divided international system. The 1946 Washington Agreement later helped resolve the conflict with the Allies over Switzerland's wartime financial relations with Germany.

Subsequent crises reinforced Switzerland's role as a destination for foreign capital. Perrenoud cites the Suez Crisis in 1956, the Cuban Missile Crisis in 1962, the Prague Spring in 1968, and the events of May